CHAPTER 10

THE MAGIC CARPET

After a while professional sport can start to feel like a treadmill on which you go around and around, making repeated circuits of the same flights, the same hotels and the same stadiums, playing over and over again against the same opponents, dealing with the same officials and the same journalists, year after year.

Perhaps some degree of monotony is unavoidable and even understandable, but I have always worked hard to approach every match with precisely the same boyish enthusiasm with which I approached every game I played with my brothers and their friends in the garden at 20 Mentz Avenue.

I have never known any other way.

Every match, every home series and tour needed to feel like a peak in its own right, an emotional and physical challenge to be embraced. Play every match as if it is your last, I used to tell myself, because, you never know, it might prove to be exactly that. Nothing can be taken for granted.

Looking back over the past 12 years, I have played a significant volume of cricket: more than 100 Test matches, more than 200 one-day internationals, more than 70 Twenty20 internationals, three ICC Cricket World Cups, three ICC Champions Trophies and no fewer than six ICC World Twenty20 tournaments, many provincial matches with the Titans and nine seasons in the Indian Premier League, initially in